COLOURED REMARKS



On May 23, Bihar CM **Samrat Choudhary** said that with nearly 4,000 CCTV cameras across Patna, AI will quickly identify criminals wearing a "*hara gamchha* (green towel)". The Opposition Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD), whose party colour is green, immediately took umbrage. Samrat, in the same speech, had clarified that he was not targeting anyone specific and had insisted that "criminals have no religion". But by then the colours had begun to bleed. Lalu Prasad's daughter Rohini Acharya hit back with references to "*bhagwa gamchha-dhari gunda*" (saffron towel-wearing goon), while brother and RJD chief Tejashwi Yadav dismissed the CM's remarks as "laughable". Now to see who wins the gamchha wars?

THE LAST SALVO



Twenty days after the bruising defeat in West Bengal, Trinamool Congress chief **Mamata Banerjee** went on Facebook Live on May 24 ready for battle: "The war is not over, the mandate had been fiddled with...." The timing was significant. The same day, the BJP comfortably won the Falta seat re-election, while her TMC finished a distant fourth.

Mamata, though, was all fire and brimstone, claiming 150 assembly seats had been "altered through electoral manipulation". Unfortunately for her, numbers on the ground seem far less obliging than the rhetoric online.

IN POOR HEALTH



There is much that ails Gujarat's civil hospitals, but it has taken health minister **Praful Pansheriya** seven months in office to discover at least some facets of the malaise. The immediate issue: a junior pharmacist accused of denying subsidised medicines to patients despite adequate stocks. Pansheriya has taken a "serious view" of the matter, says an official press release. The pharmacist has been transferred to the arid Kutch region, but the larger question is whether the action will stop there or will the state push for structural reforms in the public healthcare system?

Kaushik Deka* with *Prasad Nichenametla, Ashish Misra, Amitabh Srivastava, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar* and *Jumana Shah

HEALTH WATCH

WEIGHT LOSS DRUGS
PERILS OF PROXY ADVERTISING

By **Sonali Acharjee**

Weight loss drugs have officially entered India's culture wars. What began as a medical conversation around obesity is now spilling into advertising, influencers, wellness culture and even questions of aspiration and body image. Last week, pharmaceutical giant Eli Lilly paused its obesity-awareness campaign after regulatory scrutiny over whether it indirectly promoted Mounjaro, its blockbuster obesity and diabetes drug.

The campaign did not directly advertise the medicine. Instead, it framed obesity as a chronic disease and pushed conversations around treatment, awareness and medical support through newspapers, billboards, social media and influencer collaborations. But Indian regulators have reportedly warned that even indirect or 'surrogate' promotion of prescription drugs could violate advertising norms.

The episode highlights how rapidly GLP-1 drugs such as Mounjaro and Wegovy are reshaping urban health conversations. Once limited largely to diabetes treatment, these injections are now becoming tied to fitness culture, celebrity transformations, corporate wellness trends and social media-driven body anxieties.



Doctors say demand for obesity consultations has risen sharply in metros, especially among younger professionals seeking fast, medically backed weight loss. As India's obesity market explodes, regulators are now confronting a difficult question: when does health awareness quietly become pharmaceutical advertising?